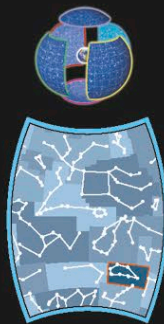


THE SOUTHERN FISH

Piscis Austrinus



SIZE RANKING 60

BRIGHTEST STAR
Fomalhaut (α) 1.2GENITIVE Piscis
Austrini

ABBREVIATION PsA

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM
September–OctoberFULLY VISIBLE
53°N–90°S

Piscis Austrinus was known to the ancient Greeks, including Ptolemy in the 2nd century CE. It depicts a fish, which was said to be the parent of the two fish represented by the zodiacal constellation Pisces.

This constellation has also been called Piscis Australis. It is made prominent in the Southern Hemisphere by the presence of 1st-magnitude Fomalhaut, or Alpha (α) Piscis Austrini (see p.253). This blue-white star lies 25 light-years away.

NEVER-ENDING DRINK

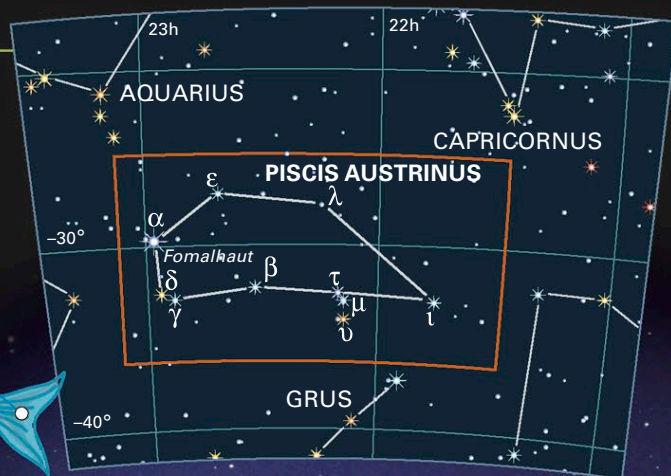
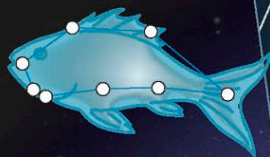
In the sky, water from the jar of the adjacent Aquarius, the Water Carrier, flows toward the mouth of the fish, marked by Fomalhaut. The star's name is an Arabic term meaning "fish's mouth."

SPECIFIC FEATURES

Beta (β) Piscis Austrini is a wide double star with components of 4th and 8th magnitudes. It is divisible through a small telescope.

More difficult to separate with a small telescope is Gamma (γ) Piscis Austrini, a closer pair of stars of 5th and 8th magnitudes.

THE SOUTHERN FISH



THE SCULPTOR

Sculptor



SIZE RANKING 36

BRIGHTEST STAR
Alpha (α) 4.3

GENITIVE Sculptoris

ABBREVIATION Scl

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM
October–NovemberFULLY VISIBLE
50°N–90°S

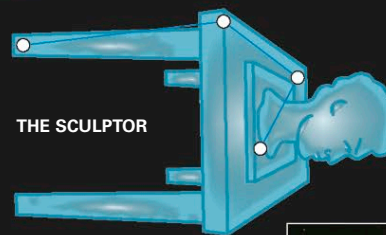
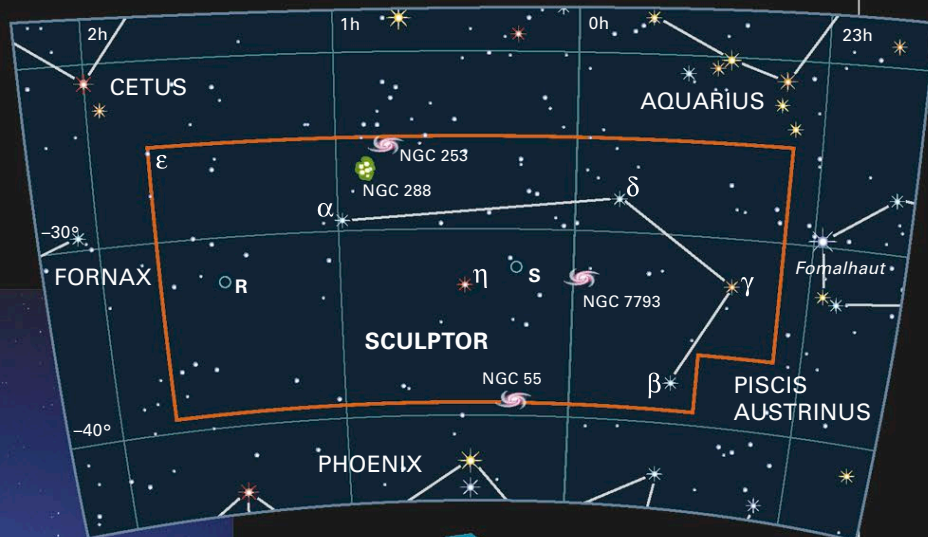
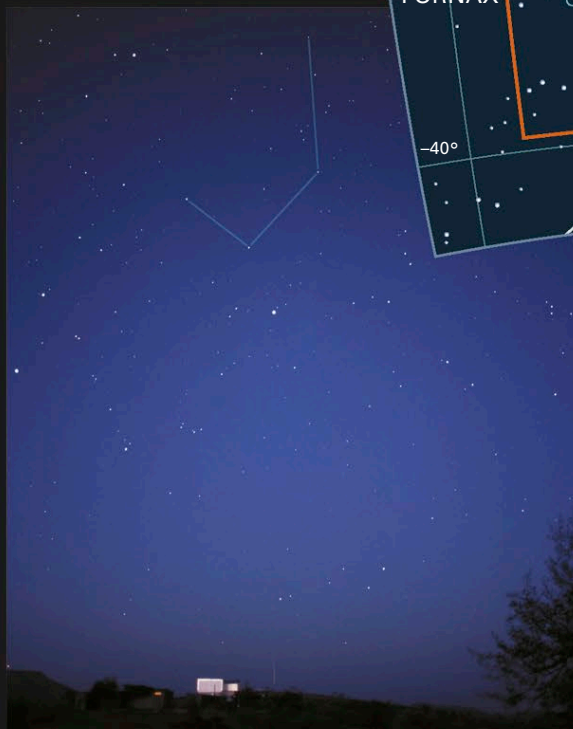
This unremarkable southern constellation was introduced in the 18th century by the French astronomer Nicolas Louis de Lacaille (see p.422). He originally described it as representing a sculptor's studio, although the name has since been shortened.

Sculptor contains the south pole of our galaxy—that is, the point 90 degrees south of the plane of the Milky Way. As a result, we can see numerous far-off galaxies in this direction, since they are unobscured by intervening stars or nebulae.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

Epsilon (ϵ) Sculptoris is a binary star that can be separated with a small telescope. Its components, of 5th and 9th magnitudes, have an orbital period of more than 1,000 years.

The spiral galaxy NGC 253 is seen nearly edge-on, so that it appears highly elongated. Under good sky conditions, it can be picked up through binoculars or a small telescope. Nearby lies the fainter and smaller globular cluster NGC 288. Another spiral galaxy is NGC 55, which is similar in size and shape to NGC 253.



THE SCULPTOR

NGC 55

This patchy-looking spiral galaxy, seen nearly edge-on, is mottled with dust clouds and areas of star formation.



BRIGHT NEIGHBOR

The faint constellation of Sculptor is outshone by Fomalhaut, the leading star of adjoining Piscis Austrinus, seen below Sculptor in this image.